SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #24 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“What the media says is normal must be right.”

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Where it often comes from

Television, streaming, music, news, and social media shape what feels ordinary: how people speak, treat each other, spend, relate, and think. Because we see it so often, it can seem like everyone does it and so it must be fine. Over time, we may adopt values without noticing.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God.” Isaiah warns, “Woe to those who call evil good and good evil.” Proverbs says, “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death.” Philippians 4:8 gives a filter: “whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable.” Common is not the same as right.

> *“Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God”* (Romans 12:2).

Also see

> “Woe to those who call evil good and good evil, who turn darkness to light and light to darkness, who replace bitter with sweet and sweet with bitter” (Isaiah 5:20).

> “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death” (Proverbs 14:12).

> “Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things” (Philippians 4:8).

> “Do not love the world or anything in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. For all that is in the world—the desires of the flesh, the desires of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not from the Father but from the world. The world is passing away, along with its desires; but whoever does the will of God remains forever” (1 John 2:15–17).

Common self-statements

- Everyone does it, so it is fine.
- If it is on TV, it is normal.
- I do not need to question what I watch.
- That is just how people live now.
- Questioning it makes me old-fashioned.
- If it is everywhere, it must be acceptable.

Common logical errors

- Bandwagon thinking: Assuming that popular means right.
- Authority bias: Treating media as a moral authority.
- Normalization: Letting repetition reduce my sensitivity.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling comfortable and concluding that it is good.

Challenging questions

- What values does the media I consume promote?
- How have those messages shaped what I expect from relationships, money, or myself?
- What does Scripture say is true, honorable, and lovely?
- What would I think of this if I had never seen it on screen?
- How does my media diet affect my mood and faith?
- What would I change in what I watch or listen to?

Truth summary

> Popular is not the same as right. I can test what I see and hear against God's word, choose what I take in, and let my mind be renewed.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Worldly
- Thinking, Healthy
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Wisdom
- Scripture/Word

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "What the media says is normal must be right"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What the media says is normal must be right." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What values does my media promote?
- ☐ How have they shaped me?
- ☐ What is true and lovely?
- ☐ What would I change?
- ☐ Who can I talk with?
- ☐ What will I test this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can test everything against God's word.
- ☐ Common is not right.
- ☐ A way that seems right can lead astray.
- ☐ I can think on what is true and lovely.
- ☐ My mind can be renewed.
- ☐ I choose what I take in.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 12:2**
  "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God."
- ☐ **Philippians 4:8**
  "Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think on these things."
- ☐ **Proverbs 14:12**
  "There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way of death."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Tested and chosen: Each week, note one message you tested against Scripture and one media change you made.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 12:2 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will be transformed by renewing my mind, not conformed to the world.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Worldly" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Audit your media. List what you watch, read, and listen to.
- [ ] Test one message. Compare it with Philippians 4:8.
- [ ] Make one change. Replace or reduce something that harms you.
- [ ] Discuss. Talk about it with a friend or family member.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What the media says is normal must be right": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A message tested
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What the media says is normal must be right.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, shape my mind with Your truth. Help me notice the messages I absorb, test them by Your word, and choose what is true, lovely, and good. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.